



Has your partner ever asked you to be party to swapping wife/husband or girlfriend/boyfriend?

YES **18** NO **77** Have thought about it **4**

Male 19 Female 16

Male 78 Female 72

Male 3 Female 12

Rest don't know/ can't say. All figures in per cent

For 1,037 of the total of 3,923 respondents, who say they have committed adultery

THE PRICE OF LOYALTY

41

PER CENT OF MEN ADMITTED THEY HAD STRAYED WHILE ONLY 8 PER CENT OF THE WOMEN SAID THEY WERE UNFAITHFUL

perors such as the Mauryas or the Mughals (Indu Sundaresan's recent book on Mehrunnisa designates her as the Emperor Jehangir's 20th wife). Marriage was often seen to cement alliances and bring in new territories in these groups. Bengali Kulin men in the 19th century served as professional husbands, sometimes to hundreds of women at a time, using the currency of their privileged caste status and the fear of inauspiciousness of unmarried women. Outside of marriage, concubinage was widespread. Upper caste men seized sexual access to women in lower caste groups, often with ritual sanction. Women had no expectation of sexual exclusivity in these scenarios.

There are also a few examples of South Asian marriage systems where multiple sexual partners for women have been the norm. Nyinba polyandry, where brothers in a household married a single wife (or two sisters), is a case in point. Sambandham marriages for Nair women, in which women may choose a series of 'visiting husbands' who return to their own homes after intimate encounters, has been another example beloved of anthropologists. In both these cases, there is no strict anxiety about exact biological fatherhood, and there are clear rules by which offspring are assigned parentage and accepted within the community. Nor does the notion of adultery clarify the significance of same-sex relation-